PSCI 3350.001 Comparative Politics

Lecture 4: Political culture and ethnopolitics

Karl Ho

Fall 2026

THE UNIVERSITY OF TEXAS AT DALLAS
School of Economic, Political and Policy Sciences

Today's puzzle

> When do identities become political — and does culture explain anything that economics has not already explained?

Chapter 3 left political culture sitting as the **intervening step** between economic change and political change. Chapter 4 asks whether it can carry that weight, or whether it is a residual we reach for when structure runs out.

Learning goals

By the end of class you should be able to:

Part 1: What is political culture?

Older than political science

Political culture is, at bottom, "the basic values, ideas, beliefs, attitudes, and orientations about politics" — **what is right and wrong, acceptable and unacceptable, in political life**.

Max Weber argued the values of Protestantism — hard work, honesty, seriousness, monetary thrift and efficiency — were especially conducive to the accumulation of capital, and so to capitalism and eventually democracy.

- A **comparative** study: Buddhism, Catholicism, Confucianism, Islam
- Other societies had *some* of these values; none had them all

Landes: the valuing of science

David Landes (1998) asks why industrialization came first to northern Europe — England, Germany, the Netherlands, Scandinavia.

His answer is cultural, but a different culture:

- A valuing of **science**
- Respect for **autonomous intellectual inquiry**
- An emphasis on **empiricism** — itself growing out of the Protestant emphasis on the observable as proof of God's favour

These values drove scientific and technological innovation from the Renaissance onward, **laying the intellectual groundwork for the Industrial Revolution**.

The war that made the field — and its flaw

As **Wiarda (1999)** notes, political culture studies were boosted by World War II.

- **Ruth Benedict** (1934; *The Chrysanthemum and the Sword*, 1954)
- **Margaret Mead** (1964)
- **Nathan Leites** (1951)

Several were commissioned by the US government — first against Japan, then against the Soviet Union.

They did study attitudes toward power, hierarchy and duty. But they were **non-comparative, single-country studies**, emphasizing **what was unique to each culture** — which gave political scientists no general method.

The breakthrough: *The Civic Culture* (1963)

Gabriel Almond and **Sidney Verba** did two things the anthropologists had not.

- Built a **framework** for systematic comparison across countries, instead of letting patterns "emerge"
- Answered the question the earlier literature had dodged: beliefs and attitudes **about what?**

> Political culture is "a set of specifically political orientations — attitudes toward the political system and its part and attitudes towards the role of the self in the system."
>
> Almond and Verba 1963, p. 12

Three orientations

Cognitive	Knowledge of and belief about the political system, its roles, the incumbents of those roles, inputs and outputs
Affective	Feelings about the political system, its roles, personnel and performance
Evaluational	Judgments and opinions about political objects — typically combining value judgments or feelings with information

Note that evaluation is **not a separate kind of thing** but a combination: feeling plus information.

Four system dimensions

Each of the three orientations can be directed at four different objects:

1. **The system as a whole** — constitutional characteristics, political structures
2. **The policy process** — input objects, e.g. interest groups, parties
3. **Policy enforcement** — how policy is implemented; output objects
4. **The self** — does the individual perceive themselves as a member of the system, with a positive impact on it?

Collapse dimensions 2, 3 and 4 into a plus or a minus and you get **the three political culture types**.

Table 4.1 · Political culture types

Ishiyama, Table 4.1

	System	Input objects	Output objects	Role of self
Parochial	–	–	–	–
Subject	+	–	+	–
Participant	+	+	+	+

Read down the **input** and **self** columns. That is where the three types actually differ — **everyone past the parochial stage notices the state and takes its benefits**.

Parochial

Citizens are only **remotely aware** of a central government, and live their lives regardless of what the state decides.

- Know little or nothing of the system, its parts, its processes
- Do not believe they should participate
- Do not expect to be beneficiaries of policy
- See no role for the self

> The old Russian peasant proverb: *"God is high above and the Tsar is far away."*

Predominates in relatively poor, underdeveloped, agrarian societies where orientations are local rather than national — but parochials can be found **in any society**.

Subject

People **know** the system and something of how it works, but see themselves as subjects to authority.

- Positively oriented to **outputs** — employment, education, healthcare — which they are quite willing to consume
- Not oriented to **inputs**; no belief in a role for the self
- Do not think they can or should articulate interests, aggregate them, or enter the policy process

Dominant in modern authoritarian states — the Soviet Union, Nazi Germany — where citizen activities are defined as **duties** rather than rights, and where the regime rests on **performance legitimacy**: **as long as the outputs keep coming, people stay loyal**.

Participant

Individuals who **know a great deal** about the system, are positively oriented to *both* inputs and outputs, and believe they have a positive role to play.

- They want to participate **and** to receive the benefits of policy
- Found in modern, developed, wealthy societies with high mass literacy and education

Almond and Verba's 1963 expectation: as a result of modernization, **the world could be expected to become more participant**.

Ideal types, individually held, nationally mixed

Three things Almond and Verba insist on, all of which students skip:

- These are **ideal types** — idealized characterizations, not descriptions of real societies
- The attitudes are held at the **individual** level
- Aggregated to the nation, every country is a **mix of all three**

So the comparative question is never "which type is this country." It is **what is the relative mix** — in some the parochial impulse predominates, in others the participant.

The civic culture is a mix, not a maximum

The mix that best supports stable democracy — the **civic culture** — is a **majority of participants**, tempered by a significant minority of **subjects** and some **parochials**.

From interviews with over **5,000 people across five countries**, conducted over five years:

- **Great Britain** and the **United States** — highest proportion of participants
- **Germany** and **Italy** — highest proportion of subjects, consistent with their recent emergence from totalitarianism
- **Mexico** — least democratic, greatest number of subjects and parochials

Note: what is the civic culture?

Almond and Verba's civic culture consists of:

- Participants only
- A majority of participants, tempered by some subjects and parochials
- An equal share of all three types
- A majority of subjects with a participant elite

A majority of participants, tempered by a significant minority of subjects and some parochials. **Too many participants was itself a destabilizing element** — which is why the answer is a mix and not a maximum.

Elazar: three American political cultures

Daniel Elazar (1972, 1994) applies the same logic inside one country, focusing on how people perceive the role of government.

Moral	Social concerns outweigh the individual; government a positive force; the commonwealth conception; politics as one of the great activities of man in search of the good society; issues matter; politicians are not to profit; more amateur participation
Individual	Government largely an impediment, to be restricted so as not to interfere with private activity; its role confined to encouraging private initiative; private concerns outweigh public
Traditional	Social and family ties prominent; emphasis on traditional hierarchies; government has a positive role but limited to maintaining the existing social order; leaders custodial rather than innovative

Part 2: Three criticisms

The three lines of attack

1. **Definition** — is the concept coherent, or stretched past usefulness?
2. **Explanatory power** — can culture be an independent variable at all?
3. **Production** — what explains where political cultures come from?

Together these drove the concept into decline. Each one also produced the repair that brought it back.

Criticism 1: the concept is stretched

Arend Lijphart (1980) is sympathetic — political culture *is* a powerful explanatory variable — but argues Almond and Verba **stretched** it.

- Beyond orientations toward the political system, into general social and personal relations
- Specifically, "the role of the self in the system"
- The result is an unnecessary **vagueness**

His repair: focus entirely on **how politics is conducted**, not on feelings about the self and how the self interacts with others.

Lijphart's replacement: how decisions get made

Consensual	Political decisions should maximize the number of points of view represented; consensus among them should be achieved; societal differences are tolerated
Conflictual / adversarial	Politics painted in stark contrasts — right and wrong — with emphasis on the triumph of one side over the other

For Lijphart (1999), consensual political culture produces "kinder and gentler" policies than majoritarian political cultures.

And the link runs both ways: consensual culture goes with **consensual institutions**, adversarial culture with **majoritarian institutions**.

Richardson: fair share and fair play

Bradley Richardson (1984), on Japanese political culture, draws the same contrast at the level of what citizens think fairness *is*.

Fair share (consensual)	What matters is that all share equally in the outcome
Fair play (adversarial)	No matter the outcome, if the game was played fairly the result is legitimate

This is a usable test. Ask of any political system: when people call an outcome unjust, **are they objecting to the distribution or to the procedure?**

The European redefinitions

Scholars took a broader view: political culture as what lets people **make sense of politics**, not as attitudes toward one particular system.

Elkins & Simeon (1979)	A set of *assumptions*; a **"mind set"** that limits attention to less than the full range of logically possible behaviours, problems and solutions
Robertson (1985)	"The totality of ideas and attitudes towards authority, discipline, governmental responsibilities and entitlements"
Rose (1980)	Sets of "values, beliefs and emotions," taken for granted, which "give meaning to politics"
Kavanagh (1985)	Disposes members to regard certain political behaviour and institutions as "normal" and others as "abnormal"
Topf (1989)	Attitudes as "expressions of values, or better, of positions in the moral order, constitutive of the political culture"
Welch (1993)	Not assumptions but **resources** — images, symbols, myths, traditions people draw on to make sense of their predicament

Criticism 2: is culture a cause or a result?

Carole Pateman (1971): if political orientations are an integral part of the political system, attitudes can exist only in relation to a **specific set of institutions**.

> Then political culture cannot be an independent variable, because **it cannot be separated from the institutional context in which it exists**.

Brian Barry goes further. Political culture is merely "reasonable expectations founded on common experience" of the existing system:

> "Obviously, if this interpretation is correct, there are no grounds for saying that the correlation arises from the conduciveness of the 'civic culture' to 'democracy', but rather for the unexciting conclusion that **'democracy' produces the 'civic culture'**."
>
> Barry 1978, pp. 51–52

Note: Barry's objection

Barry's claim that "democracy produces the civic culture" is best described as:

- A measurement-validity problem
- A reverse-causation problem
- A selection-bias problem
- A concept-stretching problem

Reverse causation. The correlation is not in dispute — **what is in dispute is which way the arrow points**, and Barry argues the civic culture is the *residue* of living under democracy rather than its cause.

Lijphart's defence, and a smaller claim

Lijphart (1980) replies that the question is wrongly posed: it is a mistake to think of culture and structure in **either/or** terms.

- Structures clearly affect political culture
- Culture clearly affects which structures emerge
- They are inherently linked and occur **simultaneously**

Elkins and Simeon (1979) offer the more modest repair: most studies fail to control for other factors.

> Political culture should not be the explanation of **first resort** but of **last resort** — what social, economic and political structures cannot explain. It is the variation in the dependent variable that structural factors leave over.

Criticism 3: where do political cultures come from?

Almond and Verba show correlations between attitudes and educational attainment, implying political culture is **produced** by individuals and institutions together.

- But they never explain how, beyond invoking **political socialization**
- And **Pateman (1980)**: socialization only takes an active role if there are *tensions* between people's independently generated orientations and how the system actually works

Definition problems, plus the independence problem, plus no account of production — together these produced **a decline in interest in the concept** in comparative politics.

Part 3: The renaissance

Why the concept came back

At the end of the 1980s, renewed interest in the United States — Europe had never abandoned it.

- **Real-world puzzles** no structural account could handle: radical Islamic fundamentalism; the extraordinary modernization of several East Asian countries
- **The collapse of the Soviet Union** and of communism in Central and Eastern Europe — how had changing political cultures brought communism down?
- **Consolidation**: the congruence of culture with institutions as a prerequisite for new democracies (Linz and Stepan 1996; Rose, Mishler and Haerpfer 1998; Diamond 1999)

Putnam (1993), *Making Democracy Work*, on the republican virtues — **civic community, tolerance, cooperation, solidarity**.

Inglehart: post-materialism

As in **Maslow's** hierarchy of needs, individuals pursue goals in hierarchical order — material needs first, non-material needs as material ones are satisfied.

Scarcity	Emphasis on economic growth and security — strong national defence, "law and order"
Affluence	Shift to personal freedom, political participation, quality of life, a clean environment

And not a passing mood: through **socialization**, post-material orientations transfer to subsequent generations and become **a stable value system rather than a volatile attitude**.

The growth that made the shift possible

Average annual growth in income per capita, **1945–1970**:

Ishiyama ch. 4

Country	Growth per year
Austria	6.69%
Germany	6.62%
Italy	5.64%
France	4.61%
Netherlands	4.12%

That growth, plus the extensive **welfare state**, produced unprecedented economic security — **and security is the mechanism** by which Inglehart's value shift occurs.

The four-item index

Inglehart's measure, built on American National Election Studies data. Respondents choose their **first** and then their **second** most desirable national goal:

1. Maintaining order in the nation
2. Giving the people more say in important political decisions
3. Fighting rising prices
4. Protecting freedom of speech

(1) and (3) → pure **materialists** · **(2) and (4)** → **post-materialists**

Inglehart 1971, p. 94

World Values Survey (2000) — highest post-materialist shares: **Australia 35%, Austria 30%, Canada 29%, United States 25%**.

The new values of the 1990s

By the 1990s the shift had produced a distinct set of political values:

- The diminishing effectiveness and acceptability of **bureaucratic authority** — small is better
- A growing emphasis on **individual freedom** and emotional experience, and the questioning of all forms of authority
- The diminishing prestige of **science, technology and rationality**, and a re-embrace of **religion**

That third item is the one that generates Table 4.2: religion returning as a basis of authority **cross-cuts the materialist/post-materialist axis** rather than lying along it.

Table 4.2 · Material versus post-material values by authority type

Ishiyama, Table 4.2

	Traditional values (materialist)	Postmodern values (post-materialist)
Rational / legal / secular (emphasis on state authority)	Post-communist Eastern Europe, China, Japan (somewhat)	Northern Europe, Canada (increasingly Japan)
Traditional authority (e.g. religion)	Poland, most of the developing world	Italy, Spain, Mexico, Argentina, the US (a borderline case), Ireland

Reading Table 4.2

- **Secular + materialist** — the post-communist states, from communism's secular legacy plus relatively lower development than the West. China likewise. **Poland is the exception**, where Catholicism is a powerful legitimizing force
- **Secular + post-materialist** — most of northern Europe, Canada, and to some extent the US. **Japan is a borderline case**: secular, and increasingly post-materialist
- **Traditional + materialist** — most of the developing world
- **Traditional + post-materialist** — Catholic southern Europe, Latin America, and arguably the US, given the strong influence of religion on its politics

The payoff for democracy: where **traditional authority** predominates, expect a less participatory impulse — close to Almond and Verba's **subject** culture. Add materialist values and you get **something less than participatory democracy**.

Postmodernization

Inglehart (1997) generalizes beyond post-materialism: western industrial democracies have entered a new phase.

> "In the postmodernization phase of development, emphasis shifts from maximizing economic gains to maximizing **subjective well-being**." (p. 86)

The post-materialist shift is "only one part of a broader shift toward postmodern values, involving changing orientations towards politics, work, family life, religion, and sexual behavior" (p. 132).

New priorities follow: environmental protection, abortion, ethnic diversity, women's issues, gay rights (p. 247).

The measurement critique

Critics (Flanagan 1982; Clarke and Dutt 1991; Duch and Taylor 1993, 1994) attack the **four-item index** itself.

Clarke et al. (1999, p. 637): substituting an unemployment statement for the standard inflation statement "has major consequences for the classification of respondents as materialist or postmaterialist."

> "When inflation is not a salient economic problem, respondents eschew the rising prices item but are forced by the form to choose one of the remaining three, none of which deals with other economic concerns they may have. Respondents who do not select the prices item have a **zero probability** of being classified as materialist."

The deeper worry: post-materialism may not be a stable value set at all, but a response to conditions — **post-materialist in good times, materialist in downturns** or under security threat.

Note: what is the Clarke et al. critique?

The Clarke et al. (1999) objection to Inglehart's index is that:

- The sample was unrepresentative
- The forced-choice format makes classification depend on which items are offered
- Post-materialism was measured in too few countries
- Respondents misunderstood the question wording

The forced-choice format. Swap the inflation item for an unemployment item and respondents get reclassified — **so the measure is partly an artefact of the instrument**, and partly of current economic conditions.

Part 4: Ethnic politics and nationalism

Why ethnicity enters a chapter on culture

As political culture came to mean a set of values through which politics is **interpreted**, it moved closer to the other shortcuts people use to make sense of politics.

- In the era of **multiculturalism**, culture became equated with **ethnicity**
- In the US especially, multiculturalism is used interchangeably with inter-ethnic or inter-racial relations

Ishiyama's justification is the close relationship between cultural and ethnic identities — **but notice that an equation has quietly been made**, and it is worth asking whether it holds.

What is "ethnicity"?

Glazer and Moynihan (1975, p. 1) remarked that "ethnicity seems to be a new term" — but the root is very old.

- From the Greek **ethnos**, originally meaning "heathen" or "pagan"
- Largely ignored by social science, with the notable exception of **Max Weber**

Two broad contemporary approaches: **primordial** and **constructivist**.

Primordialism

Ethnicity is a **natural phenomenon**, present throughout human history; modern ethnic groups have roots extending far into the past. Groups are defined by **kinship and bloodlines**.

Essentialist	The extreme version: ethnic groups are not merely historical but naturally occurring. Consistent with early-twentieth-century scientific racialism — the intellectual soil of eugenics and National Socialism (Smith 1999, pp. 4–7)
Historical	Ethnic groups are historical entities, extensions of kinship but more than kinship, defined by **cultural signs** — language, religion, traditions — that symbolize biological unity

Clifford Geertz (1973): ethnicity may not be a biological condition, but what matters is that humans *perceive* it as such — making it an objective condition, as

Constructivism

Ethnicity and ethnic identity are **malleable and flexible**.

- **Weber**: a "subjective belief" in "common descent. Whether or not an objective blood relationship exists" (1978, p. 389)
- **Schildkrout (1979, p. 184)**: the minimal definition is "the idea of common provenance, recruitment primarily through kinship, and a notion of distinctiveness, whether or not this consists of a unique inventory of cultural traits"
- **Benedict Anderson (1991)**: nations as **imagined communities** — socially constructed products of human interaction, maintained for instrumental reasons: to validate governance, to bind a community

The modernist variant

A related claim: ethnicity is **purely a modern invention**, appearing only in the modern period of world history.

- **Marx and Engels** — nations as a primarily *bourgeois* construct that would wither away after the collapse of capitalism
- **Hobsbawm (1990)** — before the industrial era there was no ideal of **politicized** ethnic identities; these were created by modernization
- **Karl Deutsch (1953)** — same point from the communications side

Note what this does to the causal story: if modernization *creates* politicized ethnicity, then ethnic conflict is **not a survival from the past but a product of development**.

Nationalism as an ideology

Ethnicity can express itself politically in many ways. In the modern era many ethnic conflicts are couched as **nationalist** struggles — but, as **Ishiyama and Breuning (1998)** note, **not all ethnopolitics is nationalistic**.

Nationalism is a **socio-political ideology** whose core principles are:

1. **Popular sovereignty** — a people must have a state
2. The **glorification of the community**

Nationalists see the establishment and protection of the nation state as the highest political goal.

And if nationalism is an ideology like any other, there can be **different types** of it — some ethnic, some not.

Greenfeld's two dimensions

Greenfeld (1992) classifies nationalisms along two questions:

1. **What is the nation?** A collection of individuals (*individualism*), or a collective entity that is more than the sum of its parts (*collectivism*)?
2. **Who belongs to the nation?** Does citizenship alone qualify (*civic*), or is membership defined by blood (*ethnic*)?

These will importantly affect not only whether democracy emerges, but **what form it takes** if it does.

Table 4.3 · Types of nationalism

Ishiyama, Table 4.3

	Civic	**Ethnic**
Individualism	Individualist / civic (US)	*Not possible*
Collectivism	Collectivist / civic (France)	Collectivist / ethnic (most of Eastern Europe)

Four cells, **three** logical types. **One combination cannot exist** — and working out why is the point of the table.

Reading Table 4.3

- **Individualist / civic — the US.** The nation is a collection of individuals; membership rests (in theory) on allegiance to a set of principles enshrined in the Constitution. **Individual rights are often held above the interests of the collective**
- **Collectivist / civic — France.** The nation is something more than a collection of individuals — *La Belle France* — yet who may belong is based on allegiance and, at least in principle, not on blood
- **Collectivist / ethnic — much of Central and Eastern Europe.** The nation is a collective unit *and* membership is defined by blood and kinship

The third type is the **most common** and the most problematic for consolidating democracy: collective interests outrank individual rights, and blood descent gives outgroups no route into the national community. Under social and economic stress this breeds intolerance, incivility, and unwillingness to compromise with "outsiders."

Note: why is one cell empty?

Why does Greenfeld's typology hold that **individualist / ethnic** nationalism is not possible?

- No such country has yet been observed
- Individualism makes belonging a matter of the individual's own allegiance, which contradicts membership by inheritance
- Ethnic nations are always large, and large nations are collectivist
- Individualism and ethnicity are measured on the same dimension

Option 2. The exclusion is **logical, not empirical** — the two dimensions give contradictory answers to the question of how a person comes to belong.

Part 5: Does diversity endanger democracy?

The pessimistic tradition

J. S. Mill (1958, p. 230)	"Free institutions are next to impossible in a country made up of different nationalities" — multinational societies as a continuous threat to social peace
Almond (1956)	The probability of violent conflict rises as a function of ethnic heterogeneity
Powell (1982)	A negative relationship between ethnic fractionalization and governmental stability, civil peace, and the prospects for democracy
Rabushka & Shepsle (1972)	Ethnic divisions are inimical to democracy — and democratic *competition* exacerbates ethnic conflict through **ethnic outbidding** by ethnic elites and their organizations
Reilly (2003)	Ethnic parties appeal specifically on ethnicity, so their emergence has a **centrifugal** effect — especially harmful where democratic institutions are fragile

The mechanism in the outbidding model: competing for the ethnic vote means mobilizing the group, and the cheapest way to mobilize is **inflammatory "us versus them" rhetoric**.

The revisionists

Fearon & Laitin (1996)	Ethnic heterogeneity does **not** predispose societies to conflict, civil war, or democratic collapse. **Population size** and the **proportion of mountainous terrain** matter far more to civil conflict than fractionalization
Horowitz (1985, 1993)	Conflict follows from diversity only at **very high** or **very low** fractionalization. Risk is highest where a majority group faces a very sizeable minority — Sinhalese and Tamils in Sri Lanka; Fijians and ethnic Indians in Fiji
Collier & Hoeffler (1998)	"Highly fractionalized societies are no more prone to war than highly homogeneous ones. The danger of civil war arises when the society is **polarized into two groups**"
Montalvo & Reynal-Querol (2005)	**Polarization**, not fractionalization, explains conflict
Reilly (2000)	In Papua New Guinea, so many groups that **no one group could monopolize power** — diversity promoted tolerance and coalition politics
Hardgrave (1993)	A similar argument for peace and democracy in India

Fractionalization is not polarization

Fractionalization — how many groups there are, and how evenly the population divides among them.

Polarization — how far the distribution approaches **two** groups of comparable size facing one another.

- Many small groups: high fractionalization, **low** polarization — and no group can rule alone
- One majority against one sizeable minority: moderate fractionalization, **high** polarization — and the worst risk

This is why the early literature kept finding a relationship and the later literature kept failing to: **they were measuring different things**.

It depends on institutions and elites

The recent literature treats ethnic cleavages as **cost-effective strategic resources** for group formation, interest definition and collective action (Fearon and Laitin 2003; Birnir 2007; Chandra 2004; Posner 2004), and makes the effect **conditional**.

Consociationalists	Represent groups broadly and you integrate subcultures into the political game. Securing minority representation integrates disaffected groups, which moderates their demands (Lorwin 1971; Nordlinger 1972; Daalder 1974; McRae 1974; Lijphart 1977)
Cohen (1997, p. 613)	"By making institutions more accessible and making ethnic cleavages more explicit, ethnic groups will engage in **more frequent but less intense** conflict"
Chandra (2004, 2005)	Attacks outbidding directly: institutions that restrict ethnic politics "to a single dimension destabilize democracy, whereas institutions that foster **multiple dimensions** of ethnic identity can sustain it" (2005, p. 236)
Birnir (2007)	Ethnic identity is a stable but flexible **information shortcut**; ethnic parties as "attractors" prefer peaceful routes to power. Violence follows from **denial of access to the executive**, not from the ethnification of politics

Note: fractionalization or polarization?

Collier and Hoeffler (1998) and Montalvo and Reynal-Querol (2005) conclude that civil conflict is best predicted by:

- The number of ethnic groups
- The degree of polarization into two opposed groups
- The size of the largest ethnic group
- The ratio of ethnic to religious cleavages

Polarization. **Highly fractionalized societies are no more prone to war than highly homogeneous ones** — the danger comes from a two-bloc structure, which is why Reilly's Papua New Guinea, with very many groups, looks peaceful rather than explosive.

Where this leaves the argument

Ishiyama's own summing up: there is **little question that culture and ethnopolitics have some kind of effect** — while the debate over whether culture is independent, and whether diversity kills democracy, remains open.

Two conclusions he does commit to:

- Where political cultures value **tolerance, moderation, compromise and civility**, democracy is easier to develop
- Deeply divided societies face **greater challenges**, but democracy is not impossible there

What is decisive is **how democratic institutions are designed**, and whether they fit a particular ethnic and cultural context — **as in a place as divided a**

Today's article: Posner (2004)

Posner, "The Political Salience of Cultural Difference" — cited in this chapter among the contingent accounts, and the reason it belongs beside it.

- The **Chewa** and **Tumbuka** straddle the Zambia–Malawi border: the same cultural difference, the same colonial-era history
- In **Malawi** they are political adversaries; in **Zambia** they are allies
- The difference is not the cleavage but the **political arena**: group size relative to the national electorate determines whether the difference is a useful coalitional building block

Read it as a design as much as an argument — **a natural experiment that holds culture constant and varies the arena**, which is how you test whether identity is politically salient rather than merely present.

For your dossier

Round 2 — the context diagnosis — asks explicitly for **cleavages**. This chapter supplies the vocabulary and, more usefully, the warnings.

Four things to try this week:

- Describe your focal country's cleavage structure in terms of **fractionalization** *and* **polarization**. They can point in opposite directions, and the difference is often the whole story
- Place its nationalism in **Table 4.3**. If the collectivist/ethnic cell fits, say what that predicts about who can enter the political community
- Before writing "the political culture there is different," apply the **Elkins and Simeon** rule: have you ruled out institutional and economic explanations first?
- Watch for **Barry's objection** in your own draft. If your evidence for a civic culture is that the country is democratic, you have assumed your conclusion

For next session

Session 6 · October 15 — Can outsiders promote democracy?

- **Ishiyama**, Chapter 6, pp. 134–156
- **Levitsky and Way**, "Linkage versus Leverage"
- Due: **Round 3** dossier — the causal argument, and the rival explanation your team rejected
- **Group A · Round 3** presentations

Chapters 3 and 4 both explained democracy from the **inside**. Chapter 6 asks how much of it was ever **decided inside the country at all**.